

## Open Hearth

by Douglxss Burley Johnson

My boots hit the slag before the fence wire stopped singing.

I ran with Jess Marrow two steps off my right shoulder and a cheap digital watch bitten into my left wrist, the kind with a black plastic strap and a face that still showed green digits after years of rain and pocket lint. The South Side stacks stood black against a thin strip of river light, five old blast furnace towers that the city keeps as a skyline and that kids our age still treat like a dare. My name is Cole Varga. I was twenty that night. The Lehigh ran cold on our left beyond the rail bed, and the air between the fence and the first brick arch smelled of wet rust and old oil.

We had cut the chain-link at a place where the mesh already sagged from other hands, pulled the gap wide enough for hips and backpacks, and gone in because Jess wanted photographs of the open-hearth floor before the city put more lights on the stacks and turned the whole ruin into a postcard. I had come because Jess cannot drive stick and my aunt's hatchback sat three blocks up on Fourth with the heat still ticking. What followed us through the cut wore a

faded hard hat and an orange vest that used to mean plant security, and the boots under that vest hit the slag in a rhythm that did not match a tired man's walk.

"Keep moving," Jess said. "Past the arches. One set of frames and we leave."

"He was at the cut when we pulled the wire," I said. "We go through and out the river side."

Through meant the open-hearth bay, a long ruin of brick and steel where men once cooked iron in furnaces the size of houses. The floor held puddles that caught oil sheen under our phone lights. Brick arches marched down the bay in a dark row. Slag crunch under boots made a dry sound that carried. I knew the bay from daytime trespasses with cousins who dared each other to touch the cold furnace shells. I did not know it at night with a changed watchman on our heels and a watch on my wrist that Aunt Lila had pressed into my hand the week she cleaned her last office on the north side.

Aunt Lila had worked third shift with a mop and a prayer list. She gave me the watch on her porch with the strap already worn soft.

"When your mouth goes quiet in a bad place, the dark gets a vote," she said. "You keep speaking. Short. Plain. Keep your feet moving while you talk. The Lord hears work better than speeches."

I had laughed and put the watch on and gone to class. Tonight the watch face showed 3:00 in green, a countdown I had not set, and the hard-hat man came through the fence cut behind us with a sound like breath drawn through a cracked pipe.

Jess raised her camera. Under the flash the hard-hat face turned toward us, a man's face and not a man's face in the same instant. His eyes held too steady under the brim. His mouth opened on a wet noise that was not a warning. We ran. He came after us across the slag, and the

green digits on my wrist held at 3:00 while my mouth started the short work Aunt Lila had drilled into me without calling it a drill.

"Keep us moving," I said under my breath, boots already striking puddle and brick. "Hold what I cannot see. Jesus, keep our feet."

Green digits stayed put. Jess's camera strap slapped her chest. Behind us the hard-hat boots scraped slag in a wrong meter, too even, too sure.

"What does he want," Jess said.

"Us quiet," I said. "Or us stopped."

"Then do not stop."

We hit the first arch. Cold brick scraped my shoulder. A puddle threw oil rainbow under Jess's beam and then went black again when she killed the light. The hard-hat man took the arch without slowing. In the thin river light I saw the vest hang wrong on one side, as if the ribs under it had learned a new cage. He lifted his head and the smell of wet rust thickened into burned grease and river mud.

Jess said a word her mother hates and put on speed.

The open-hearth floor opened wider past the second arch, a concrete plain broken by rail stubs and the round footprints of furnaces long gone. Wind shoved through missing wall panels and brought the Lehigh's cold up into the bay. I did not stop for the view of the stacks through a torn sheet of corrugated metal. The hard-hat boots hit the floor behind us while we were still on the open stretch. Slag sprayed. Jess's camera swung and cracked against a rail stub hard enough that the battery door popped and skittered into a puddle. She did not go after it.

"Leave it," I said, and we ran again toward the third arch where the bay narrowed between standing brick and a fallen crane rail that made a low trip hazard in the dark.

My mouth kept the short petitions going, breath and boots and words in one chain.

"Keep us moving. Hold the dark. Jesus, keep our feet."

Green digits held at 3:00. When my mouth skipped a beat to gulp air, the 3 flipped to 2:59 and then 2:58 before I found the words again, and the count climbed back toward 3:00 as if the watch were a patient animal that preferred work to silence.

Jess saw the face when a break in the wall let in street light from the South Side.

"Cole. Your watch."

"I know."

"That is not how timers work."

"I know."

A side aisle of broken brick opened left of the main bay, a chute where a wall had come down and left a slope of rubble toward a lower service floor. Jess took the main path. I turned my head and saw the hard-hat man close enough that the vest zipper showed, dull metal. He reached with a hand whose fingers bent wrong at the first knuckle. I cut left into the rubble chute because the main bay was a funnel and funnels favor the stronger pursuer.

Loose brick slid under my boots and my palms went raw on cold grit while the watch strap dug into my wrist. Far left, the Lehigh made a continuous low sound against the old plant bulkhead, and a single train horn barked on the Reading side and then faded. Behind me the hard-hat man entered the chute and the loose brick under him moved in a sheet, and he rode it the way a man rides a bad ladder, knees wrong, vest flapping. He made a sound then that had consonants in it and no mercy.

"Cole," Jess yelled from the bay above. "This way."

I clawed up to the main floor and Jess hauled on my sleeve, and we ran again with my right palm bleeding onto the camera strap she had shoved into my free hand while first light still refused the river and the stacks held their dark like a closed fist.

Past the fourth arch the bay ended in a partial collapse, brick and I-beam in a heap that left only a crawl gap and a service door hanging on one hinge. Beyond the door a narrow catwalk ran toward the river side of the plant, toward fence and rail and the long way back to Fourth Street. We hit the door together. The hinge screamed. The hard-hat man cleared the third arch behind us with that wrong even gait and the burned-grease smell rolling ahead of him like weather.

Jess shoved through. I followed. The catwalk grated under our boots, open metal with cold air coming up from a drop into dark machinery pits, and my mouth kept the petition going without a gap.

"Keep us moving. Hold what I cannot see. Jesus, keep our feet."

Green digits flicked 2:59, climbed back to 3:00, and held.

Jess stopped at a turn where the catwalk split, one spur toward the stacks silhouette, one spur toward a gate I could smell before I saw it, wet paint and old chain. She put her hands on the rail and spat into the dark.

"We need a second," she said. "I cannot hear him over your muttering."

I stopped the petition.

Mute sat in my mouth like a stone I had chosen to hold. Green digits dropped in a rush from 2:55 through 2:50 toward 2:40 while the hard-hat boots hit the catwalk behind us in that even meter, closer, and the wet pipe-breath sound filled the turn. Jess's eyes went to my wrist and then to the dark behind my shoulder.

"Cole."

"I heard you," I said, and I put the words back into the air while my boots were already moving toward the gate spur. "Keep us moving. Hold the dark. Jesus, keep our feet."

Our count slowed its fall, hung at 2:22, then climbed a digit at a time as breath and petition found the same pace again. Behind us the hard-hat man reached the split and took the gate spur without pausing to choose, hard-hat brim level, vest zipper catching a scrap of light and throwing it.

The gate was a plant exit door set in a brick stub wall, the kind with a crash bar and a chain looped through the handle on our side, padlock open and chain slack from other hands that had used this cut before. Jess hit the crash bar. The door gave two inches and stopped on a bent latch plate, then she hit it again until metal barked and the door still held.

I put both hands on the crash bar beside hers and we drove together. The latch plate screamed and opened a gap wide enough for a shoulder. Jess turned sideways and shoved through. I followed with the watch face pressed to the bar under my left wrist, green digits still climbing, mouth still on the short work.

"Keep us moving. Keep our feet."

Outside the door the ground fell to slag and weeds and a fence line that ran toward the river rail bed. Cold hit my face full of Lehigh damp. Off to our right the stacks rose in black towers with a few city lights picking out their ribs. Behind us the hard-hat man hit the bent door and the crash bar slammed; the door stuck on the latch plate the way it had for us until he pushed and the plate held for a breath and then started to give.

Jess ran for a second fence cut she had marked on the way in, a place where mesh hung loose over a concrete footing. I ran with her. My palms left blood on the crash bar and then on

the mesh when I pulled the gap. The watch strap caught on a wire barb and I tore it free without looking down at the count.

Behind us the hard-hat man cleared the door and his boots hit slag, burned-grease smell coming with him into the open air. Jess was already through the mesh, backpack snagged, camera body hanging empty without its battery. I shoved the mesh wider and drove my shoulders through while my mouth kept the petition in a hard whisper that cost breath I needed for the run.

"Keep us moving. Hold what I cannot see. Jesus, keep our feet."

On the far side of the fence the ground was ordinary South Side gravel and a weed strip along the rail. Aunt Lila's hatchback sat three blocks up where we had left it, a dark shape under a sodium lamp. Jess grabbed my wrist as we cleared the last of the mesh and turned the watch face toward the river light, where the green digits sat steady again at 3:00.

The hard-hat man reached the fence on the plant side and put both hands on the mesh with fingers bent wrong at the knuckle. He pulled once and the cut gap yawned, then he stopped as if the wire had spoken a language he could not cross while the green digits held and my mouth stayed on the work. Under the brim his head tipped, and the wet pipe-breath sound went thin.

"You keep talking," he said. The voice was a night watchman's voice sandpapered down to a rasp. "The old Harlan would have written you up for the cut. This Harlan cannot finish the catch while your mouth works that way."

Jess stood with gravel under her shoes and did not step closer to the fence.

Harlan's hands left the mesh. He backed into the slag dark toward the open-hearth bay, vest wrong on the ribs, gait still even and wrong. He did not look back. We listened until the scrape of his boots faded under the distant interstate hum on the far side of the river valley.

Jess bent and picked a piece of slag out of her shoe tread and flicked it into the weeds. Her shoulder would bruise where the camera had cracked against the rail stub. She hung the empty camera on her neck by the strap and stared at the watch still biting my wrist.

"You going to explain that," she said.

"Not with a speech," I said. "Aunt Lila gave me a watch and a work order. Keep speaking. Keep moving. He stopped at the fence while I did both."

"I saw him stop," Jess said. "I also saw a plant ghost in a hard hat move like a problem that belongs in a movie. I am not joining your aunt's church because a Casio got stubborn on a countdown."

"I know," I said.

Mute sat between us for a stretch of river wind. Jess's jaw worked. She wanted an argument that would put the night back into a box labeled adrenaline and bad light. I did not give her the argument she wanted. My hands stayed on the watch strap, fingers finding the buckle, then letting it alone.

We walked the gravel toward Fourth with our heads turned enough to watch the fence line. No orange vest reappeared. At the hatchback the sodium lamp put a dirty yellow circle on the hood. Dew had started on the windshield. Jess rode shotgun with her cracked camera in her lap and did not turn the radio on. I drove us toward the north side with the heat on low and my wet boots drying against the pedals. At Aunt Lila's porch the kitchen light was still on. She took one look at my palm and the watch face and put a dish towel under my hand.

"You kept moving," she said.

"Through the open hearth," I said. "He wanted us quiet. I spoke the short work. He could not finish the catch at the fence while the digits held."



She poured coffee that had sat on the warmer too long and set the mug where I could reach it with my clean hand. "Prayer is keep-moving work when the dark presses. Mouth and feet together. A speech in the ruins is for people who have already stopped."

Jess stood by the porch rail with her jacket still zipped and shook her head once, done talking for the night.

"I'll grant the stop," she said. "I won't grant the metaphysics before breakfast. Cole, text me when your hand's cleaned up. I need a new battery door and a story I can turn in that does not mention countdown watches in dead mills."

Jess left, and the screen door slapped behind her. Aunt Lila washed the blood off my palm under cold water and checked the watch face under the porch light. The green digits showed ordinary time again, 4:17, no countdown, no climb. The strap still held the barb tear from the fence mesh.

I am twenty-four now. I still drive past the South Side stacks when the light is low. The open-hearth bay still holds its brick arches and its oil puddles. The fence cut we used got patched and then cut again by other hands. Harlan's hard hat, if it was ever a living man's hat, does not walk that bay in any report the city posts. Jess got her class credit with photographs taken at a daylight museum overlook on a different morning, and she still sits across from me at a diner on Third and argues that prayer is a noise brave people make when the body runs out of options. She will grant the stop at the fence. She will not grant a Person on the other end of Aunt Lila's short work order.

I keep the watch on the same wrist. The barb tear in the strap is closed with a twist of electrical tape. On mornings when the Lehigh wind comes up the South Side smelling of wet rust and river cold, I check that the face still lights the way some people check a spare tire. I do not

start the countdown for show. I do not preach it at Jess. When the dark presses and my mouth wants to go quiet, my boots already know the next step, and my mouth finds the short work while my grip takes the next bar.

If you ever cut the mesh on the river side of those stacks before first light and hear boots that hit slag wrong behind you, keep your feet moving and your mouth on the short petition a trusted person taught you. The veil along the old open hearth thins in the cold hour. The watch still fits a wrist.

END